ZION

THE KINGDOM OF THE HEART

The story of the boat that a carpenter built

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This edition is a literary legend. The Gospels do not tell of a boat built by the carpenter's own hands; the authorial images and parables are not newly found sayings.

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A word before the voyage

Hope is an anchor of the soul, sure and firm.
— Letter to the Hebrews 6:19 (own translation)

This book is a story. It tells of a carpenter of Nazareth who made tables, doors and yokes for oxen, and also a boat that no one had asked for — and of where that boat sailed.

It is not a text from Scripture. Scripture does not tell of a boat that Jesus built with his own hands. The book imagines it the way legends imagine: so that the story we already know can be heard more deeply. Every chapter therefore stands on real verses, and every chapter ends with a table called Anchor of truth. It states what is Scripture, what is church tradition, what is history, what is legend and what is only an image of this book. The reader can always decide for himself what he believes and what he merely enjoys as a tale.

The last two parts are different. They grow out of the story of ZION, the world to which the book belongs, and they are marked as a separate layer. Whoever does not want to read them loses nothing: the carpenter's story ends in the harbour in the seventeenth chapter and continues with the epilogue.

The book promises nothing and recommends nothing except slow reading. It suits readers from roughly twelve years up; it speaks of the crucifixion soberly.

Prologue · At the gate

At the edge of the new land stood a gate. It was not of stone and not of iron. It was made of two lights: one warm and low like a fire in a hearth, the other high and clean like a lantern lifted above water.

Two women waited at the gate. Radha held in her palms a bowl of salt and honey. Elizabeth held a lantern.

Radha welcomed everyone who came and asked nobody where he was from. Elizabeth asked one thing. She shone for those who would come in a hundred years, and from everyone who entered she wanted to know: "What will be left of you?"

That evening a pilgrim came. He led by the hand a child named Lumi, who had not spoken all the way and only pointed her finger at the places where the mist was tearing. The pilgrim was tired. In his pockets he had dust from many shores and nothing more.

"What will be left of you?" asked Elizabeth.

He was silent a long time. He could have said that he built, that he wrote, that he counted. But all of it was only dust. So he said the one thing he was sure of.

"I know a story. It is about a boat that a carpenter built for those who would one day need it. Perhaps it is the boat we sailed here on."

Elizabeth did not raise the lantern higher. She only let it shine. She looked at the child for a long while, the way a person looks at an old photograph of himself.

"Then tell it," said Radha. "But first salt and honey. Whoever enters must not speak of hunger."

The pilgrim sat down on the stone at the gate, took a pinch of salt into his palm, tasted the honey and began.

(The frame belongs to the ZION telling: the gate, Radha, Elizabeth and Lumi are characters of the story, the pilgrim is the reader. None of it is Scripture or history.)

PART I · THE CARPENTER

1 · The carpenter of Nazareth

Story

In Nazareth, in the hills above Galilee, there stood a workshop that everyone knew. It smelled of freshly cut cedar and olive wood, and on the walls hung chisels whose handles three generations of palms had polished. The carpenter inherited it from his father, and the father from his.

He made yokes for oxen, so that the weight would not press on the neck. He made tables where families gathered over bread, and doors that kept the wind outside and the warmth within. People said: what the carpenter makes, holds.

In the evening, when the last customer had gone, his mother set on the table a bowl of coarse salt and a loaf of bread. Such was the custom of that workshop: whoever entered received bread and salt, and nobody asked him where he came from or where he was going. And from that salt the carpenter always poured a handful into a small clay cup and carried it in his bag wherever he went.

And when even the street had gone quiet, the carpenter built something else. In the back corner, under a cloth, a boat was slowly growing.

It was not large: for one crew, perhaps for twelve. Its keel was of a single trunk of cedar, its ribs bent over steam, the way fingers bend around a cup. The neighbours came to look and shook their heads.

"A boat? Here?" Nazareth lay in the hills, and to the lake of Kinneret it was a whole day's journey. "Who will you sell it to, carpenter?"

He answered strangely: "I am not selling it. I am building it for those

who will one day need it."

And he planed on. At no work was he as slow as at this one: he laid every plank three times before nailing it. When they asked him why, he said:

"A boat that is to carry people through a storm is not built in a hurry. It is built in the days when it is calm, so that it holds when the calm is over."

One thing was missing on it: a sail. When they asked about it, he answered: "Let those who will sail bring the sails."

Once his mother came upon him late in the evening at his work. She stood in the doorway a long time. Then she crossed the room, laid her palm on the keel the way a hand is laid on a sleeping child's forehead, and said nothing. There was no need. Both knew that this boat was not made only of wood.

The keel is laid.
Who builds in the days of calm
stands when the storm comes.

From Scripture and tradition

Mk 6:3 — "Is this not the carpenter, the son of Mary?" (own translation). The Greek word tektōn means craftsman, builder; it is the only place in the gospels where Jesus is named by his trade.

Mt 13:55 — "Is this not the son of that carpenter?" The trade was handed down from father to son.

Mt 11:29–30 — the image of the yoke that does not press. According to early Christian tradition (Justin Martyr, 2nd century)

Jesus himself made ploughs and yokes.

About the so-called hidden years (from childhood to about thirty) Scripture is silent. The story puts a boat into that silence.

In 1986 a first-century boat was found in the mud by the Sea of Galilee, about eight metres long, of cedar and other woods. It is said to have carried around fifteen people. Nothing provably connects it with Jesus.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Jesus was a carpenter (tektōn), the workshop in Nazareth	Scripture — Mk 6:3; Mt 13:55
Yokes as a trade, the yoke that does not press	Scripture and tradition — Mt 11:30; Justin Martyr
Building the boat in the workshop, conversations with the neighbours	STORY — an image of this book
The mother with the bowl of salt, her palm on the keel	STORY — an image of this book
"A boat is built in the days of calm"	An image of this book, in accord with the tradition of the church as a ship

2 · Wood and pitch

Story

With wood the carpenter was strict. He walked among the stores and the piles and chose slowly: one plank lifted his hand, another was not allowed to. The boy from the neighbouring workshop, who was learning from him, could not bear it one day.

"Master, what are you looking at? It is only wood."

"Only wood," repeated the carpenter and laid his palm on the plank as on a shoulder. "Look more closely. Each one grew differently. One in the wind, one in the shade, one bent by a rock. The boat is not to correct them, it is to receive them as they are. You do not cover a crack. You go around it and let it tell how the tree grew."

And he added more quietly, rather to himself: "People are like wood. Each one is bent to a different side. A good boat does not remake them. It carries them."

When the ribs were paired, he brought hot pitch, dark and thick, fragrant with resin. He painted every seam with it, inside and out, until the hull shone like dark honey.

"Why inside too?" asked the boy. "Water does not run there."

"It does. From sweat, from tears, from the rain that falls on people into the boat. The pitch inside does what you cannot see from outside: it keeps the water out, even the water that comes from above."

In the old books that nobody in the workshop read and yet everyone knew, it was written that Noah once built like this: of gófer wood, and smear it with pitch inside and outside. And the oldest

interpreters said that the Hebrew word for pitch, kofer, has the same root as the word for reconciliation. For that which covers and keeps the water out.

"Remember," said the carpenter. "What covers people is what carries them across the water."

Plank to plank, seam to seam.
What you do not cover leaks.
What you cover carries.

From Scripture and tradition

Gen 6:14 — Noah is to make the ark "of gófer wood" and smear it with pitch inside and outside (own translation). The word gófer appears nowhere else in the Bible and we do not know what kind of wood it was.

kofer (כֹּ֫פֶר) — the Hebrew word for pitch belongs to the root kfr, "to cover", from which comes also kipur, reconciliation (Yom kippur, the Day of Atonement). The linguistic link is documented; reading the pitch as "the covering of sin" is rabbinic and Christian interpretation.

1 Pet 3:20–21 — Noah's ark as a prefiguration of baptism. Church tradition reads the ark as an image of salvation through water.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Gófer wood, pitch inside and outside	Scripture — Gen 6:14 (about the ark, not about this boat)
Kofer and the root for "to cover"	Language and interpretive tradition

The choosing of planks as a parable about people	STORY — an image of this book
The carpenter's conversation with the boy	STORY — a literary scene

3 · The boat on the Kinneret

Story

One morning, before the fishermen returned from the night's haul, they carried the boat down from Nazareth to the lake. They travelled a whole day on ox-carts, and the carpenter walked beside it with his hand on the hull, the way a hand is held on a horse's withers.

By the lake of Kinneret, by the town of Capernaum, waited water that was a lake and at the same time a sea for all who lived from it. The fishermen were just then untangling empty nets. All night they had caught nothing.

The carpenter left his boat on the shore, smooth, not yet launched. It was not its hour. People began to gather around him, and on the shore stood two boats. One belonged to the fisherman Simon. The carpenter asked him to push off a little from the shore, sat down in it and began to speak. Not from the synagogue, not from a platform, but from a boat. The water carried his voice further than walls, and even the furthest heard him, those who would not have stood at the door.

When he had finished, he said to Simon: "Put out into the deep and let down your nets."

Simon looked at his hands, torn by the whole night. "Master, we have laboured all night and caught nothing. But at your word I will let down the nets."

He let them down and the net trembled so that it began to tear. They called to the second boat, to their partners James and John, and when they had loaded the fish into both, the boats sank so low that

they almost went down. Simon fell at the carpenter's feet. "Go away from me, Lord, I am a sinful man."

"Do not be afraid," said the carpenter. "From now on you will catch people."

The fishermen pulled the boats ashore, left the nets and the catch, and followed him.

That evening, when the shore had emptied, the carpenter came to the boat he had brought from Nazareth and laid his palm on it. "Now," he said.

They lowered it into the water. It lay on the surface quietly, as if it had been there since the beginning, as when a thing rightly made comes home.

Simon came to look at it. "Why did you build it, carpenter? You will not sell it."

"I built it so that one could teach from it," he answered. "And so that one could sail away from it, when there is somewhere to go."

The boat stayed on the water, and from that moment it was never again only wooden.

Let down the nets where you no longer believe.
The boat that waited on the shore
got its water.

From Scripture and tradition

Lk 5:1–11 — the sermon from the boat, the miraculous catch, Simon Peter, James and John. Luke mentions two boats by the shore (5:2) and "partners in the other boat" (5:7); the boat from

which Jesus teaches belongs to Simon.

Mk 1:16–20; Mt 4:18–22 — the calling of the fishermen, "fishers of people".

Kinneret — the Hebrew name of the lake, connected with the word kinnor, harp, from the shape of the lake. The lake is also called the Sea of Gennesaret, of Galilee, or of Tiberias.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The sermon from the boat, the miraculous catch, the calling of the fishermen	Scripture — Lk 5:1–11; Mk 1:16–20
Two boats by the shore, the boat belongs to Simon	Scripture — Lk 5:2–3
The boat from Nazareth waits on the shore and is launched in the evening	STORY — an image of this book
The conversation "why will you not sell it?"	STORY

4 · Salt and fish

Story

The fish that were pulled from the lake that day could not all be eaten at once. There were more of them than the shore could take, and whoever lives by water knows what that means: within three days they are gone.

So they carried them to Magdala. It was a small town further along the shore, where fish were made into stores for the whole land. Salt could be smelled there before the town could be seen. They brought it on camels from the Salt Sea, as they called the water in the south in which nothing lives, and the women poured it by handfuls onto the fish, layer after layer, into wooden vats.

The carpenter went with them. He stood by a vat and watched a woman with hands cracked by salt lay the fish in rows.

"What are you doing?" he asked.

"I am salting fish," she answered without raising her eyes. "What else? I am not like those who walk with you. I only salt."

He smiled. "Exactly that," he said. "If your hands were not here, the Kinneret would spoil and half the land would go hungry."

The woman was silent. Then she reached into the pocket of her apron, took out a piece of bread, added a handful of salt to her palm and gave it to him without a word, the way it is done where they do not ask who you are. He poured the handful of salt into his clay cup, beside the salt he carried from home, and remembered the bowl on the table in Nazareth.

Then he turned to those who followed him, and to the women at the

vats, and said a sentence that was repeated for a long time afterwards, because nobody expected it.

"You are the salt of the earth."

Nobody spoke. They were fishermen, widows, a tax collector and women with cracked hands. None of them felt like the salt of anything.

"Salt cannot be seen," he said. "What can be seen is the bread that tastes of something and the fish that keeps. But if salt stopped being salty, what would you salt with? It would be good for nothing, only thrown out on the road for people to tread underfoot. Have salt in yourselves. And live together in peace."

In the evening they sailed back. The vats smelled in the distance. Simon, silent the whole way, finally asked: "Master, that salt. Is it something we are to do, or something we are to be?"

"Salt does nothing," said the carpenter. "It is. And that is precisely why it holds."

Salt cannot be seen.
What can be seen is the bread that tastes of something,
and the fish that keeps.

From Scripture and tradition

Mt 5:13 — "You are the salt of the earth"; salt that loses its taste is good for nothing. The gospel places this in the Sermon on the Mount. The book moves those words to the lake, to people who knew salt on their own hands.

Mk 9:50 — "Have salt in yourselves and live together in peace." Salt

within, like the kingdom within (ch. 9).

Lev 2:13; Num 18:19; 2 Chron 13:5 — the "salt of the covenant" (Hebrew berit melach): sacrifices were salted and the covenant of salt was perpetual.

Magdala — a fishing town on the western shore of the lake, in Greek Tarichea; the name is derived from the word for pickled, salted fish.

Salt Sea — the Old Testament name for the Dead Sea (Gen 14:3). Salt was also obtained from there in Palestine.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
"You are the salt of the earth"; salt that loses its taste	Scripture — Mt 5:13 (moved to the lake)
"Have salt in yourselves"	Scripture — Mk 9:50
The salt of the covenant	Scripture — Lev 2:13
Magdala as a town of salted fish	History — to be verified before print
The woman at the vat, bread and salt, the answer "Salt does nothing. It is."	STORY — an image of this book

5 · Twelve on board

Story

The boat was built for twelve. That is what the carpenter said in Nazareth when the neighbours asked, and they thought he was joking. Now it sailed on the lake with twelve benches waiting for twelve people, and the one who had planed them knew who would sit on them.

He went up on a mountain and called those he wanted. They were not the most learned, the strongest or the most devout. He called them the way a person calls who knows that the benches were planed precisely for them.

Simon, a fisherman, to whom he gave the name Peter, Rock. James and John, the sons of Zebedee, who were called Sons of Thunder, because they thundered before they thought. Andrew, who brought his brother. Philip and Bartholomew. Matthew, who was a tax collector and could count. Thomas, who wanted to see. James son of Alphaeus and Thaddaeus. Simon, called the Zealot. And Judas of Kerioth, who was given the purse because he could handle money; the carpenter looked at him a moment longer than at the others.

They sat down. Twelve benches, twelve places, and nobody had to guess where he belonged. On the stern, by the steering oar, lay one more cushion of coarse cloth. It belonged to no bench. It belonged to the carpenter.

"It is a boat for twelve," said Simon. "And you counted us on your fingers."

"Twelve benches," said the carpenter. "And a thirteenth cushion. For

the one who sleeps when it seems to the others that everything is perishing."

The fishermen laughed. Matthew counted. Judas patted the purse at his belt, and the carpenter turned away to the water.

The boat no longer carried only wood. Now it carried names too.

Twelve benches, twelve names.
On the stern a cushion for the one
who is not afraid to sleep.

From Scripture and tradition

Mk 3:13–19; Mt 10:1–4; Lk 6:12–16 — the calling of the twelve. The lists differ slightly (for instance Thaddaeus and Judas son of James).

Mk 3:17 — James and John received the name Boanerges, "sons of thunder".

Jn 12:6; 13:29 — Judas kept the common purse.

Mk 4:38 — Jesus sleeps on the stern "on the cushion"; the book introduces the cushion in advance.

The number twelve — the twelve tribes of Israel (cf. Mt 19:28; Rev 21:12–14).

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The twelve disciples and their names	Scripture — Mk 3:13–19
Judas and the purse	Scripture — Jn 12:6

Twelve benches and the cushion on the stern	STORY — derived from Mk 4:38
That the boat was built for twelve	STORY — an image of this book

6 · The storm on the lake

Story

The Kinneret can make a storm in an hour. Winds rush down from the mountains into the basin of the lake like water into a funnel, and the surface that carried the sky in the morning can carry fear by evening.

That evening they were sailing to the other shore. The carpenter lay down on the stern, his head on a cushion he had planed himself, and fell asleep. A storm rose, waves broke over the sides and the boat filled with water. The disciples, people of the water, bailed it out and shouted against the wind.

And he slept. He slept the way a man sleeps who built his boat himself and knows every rib of it.

"Master!" they shouted. "Do you not care that we are perishing?"

He got up. He looked at the wind and at the water. Not angrily, rather like a craftsman looking at work that is not yet finished. And he said to the lake what is said to a boat that holds: "Be silent. Be still."

The wind ceased and a great silence came. Such a silence that they heard the drops dripping from the steering oar.

The disciples looked at one another and were more afraid than before the storm. "Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?"

The carpenter turned to them, to their fear, and asked quietly: "Why are you so afraid? Do you still have no faith?"

Later, when they told of it, someone remembered the old psalm about those who go down to the sea in ships and do their work on the great waters, and how in their trouble they cry out and he stills the storm and brings them to the harbour they long for.

Who knows his boat can sleep.
Who does not know it calls out.
And the storm obeys the one who built it.

From Scripture and tradition

Mk 4:35–41 (also Mt 8:23–27; Lk 8:22–25) — the storm, Jesus asleep on the stern on the cushion, the calming, the question "who is this?".

Ps 107:23–30 — the psalm about seafarers, which the church has read from the beginning as the background of this story.

Jon 1 — Jonah sleeps in the hold of the boat in the storm; the storm ceases when he is thrown into the sea. The contrast: here it is the one who did not cause the storm who sleeps.

The mustard seed does not belong to this story; it comes from other places (Mt 17:20; Lk 17:6). In Mk 4:40 Jesus reproaches the disciples for their little faith.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The storm, the sleeping Jesus, the calming, the question "who is this?"	Scripture — Mk 4:35–41
Psalm 107 as the background	Scripture and liturgical tradition
The boat is the one from chapter 1, the cushion on the stern	STORY — an image of this book

"He knows every rib of it" STORY — an image of this book

7 · Bread on the other shore

Story

The Twelve returned from their journeys and wanted to tell of them, but there were so many people around them that they had no time even to eat. "Come away," said the carpenter, "to a deserted place, and rest a little." And they got into the boat.

But the people saw them sail off and ran along the shore. They walked faster than the boat sailed against the wind, and when it came in, five thousand men were already waiting there, not counting women and children.

The carpenter stepped out and looked at them. They were like sheep without a shepherd. He taught them all day, and when it began to grow dark the disciples came to him. "This is a deserted place and it is late. Send them away, so they can buy food in the villages."

"You give them something to eat," he said.

Matthew, who could count, quickly calculated that even two hundred denarii would not be enough. "How many loaves do you have?" asked the carpenter. "Go and see."

Andrew returned, leading a boy. The boy had five barley loaves and two fish, salted and dried, the way the fishermen carried them when they went far. He handed them over the way one hands over what one cannot eat alone.

The carpenter had the people sit down in groups on the green grass. He took the loaves and the fish, looked up to heaven, blessed them, broke them and gave them to the disciples to distribute. Everyone ate and was satisfied. And when they gathered what was left, there

were twelve full baskets of it. Twelve, and each of the twelve carried one.

The boy went home with an empty satchel and did not fall asleep for a long time that evening. He could not understand how the whole shore had been fed from what he gave.

What you hold in your palm is little.
What you give is enough for all.
And twelve baskets are left over.

From Scripture and tradition

Mk 6:30–44; Mt 14:13–21; Lk 9:10–17; Jn 6:1–14 — the feeding of the five thousand. Only John mentions the boy with the loaves and fishes (6:9). All four gospels mention the twelve baskets of leftovers.

Mk 6:34; Num 27:17 — "sheep without a shepherd".

Barley bread was the bread of the poor.

The twelve baskets are read in tradition in relation to the twelve disciples and the twelve tribes of Israel.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The feeding of the five thousand, twelve baskets	Scripture — Mk 6:30–44; Jn 6:1–14
The boy with the loaves and fishes	Scripture — Jn 6:9
The boat as a place of rest, which the people outrun	Scripture — Mk 6:32–33
Fish salted and dried	STORY — an addition (John says only "fish")

Each of the twelve carries one basket STORY — an image of this book

8 · Steps on the water

Story

Immediately after that the carpenter sent the disciples into the boat, to sail ahead to the other shore, before he dismissed the crowds. He himself went up on the mountain to pray. Evening came and he was there alone.

The boat was in the middle of the lake, far from the shore. The wind blew into its face and the rowers struggled against it. It was dark. The carpenter saw them from the mountain, how they laboured, and before dawn, in the fourth watch of the night, he went to them. On the water.

The boat he had built carried twelve people and he was not in it. For the first time. The waves beat against ribs that did not bend. It held. It held even when the builder was far away.

The disciples saw him and cried out in terror. "It is a ghost!"

"Do not be afraid," he said. "I am. Do not be afraid."

Simon, a fisherman who had known the lake all his life and knew that one does not walk on it, called out: "Lord, if it is you, command me to come to you on the water."

"Come."

Simon climbed out of the boat. He took one step and then a second. He walked. He walked on the water and for a while heard nothing but his own breathing. Then he looked at the wind and at the waves and saw that this could not be done. And he began to sink.

"Lord, save me!"

The carpenter gave him his hand. "You of little faith. Why did you doubt?"

They got into the boat together and the wind fell. Nobody asked who he was. They sat like people who have just understood something that cannot be said: that the boat carries even when the builder is not on board. And that a step on the water is not the art of walking. It is the art of not looking at the waves and looking at the one who calls.

The boat carries even without the builder.
A person can take a step on the water
as long as he does not look at the waves.

From Scripture and tradition

Mt 14:22–33; Mk 6:45–52; Jn 6:15–21 — the walking on the lake. Simon's step on the water is only in Matthew (14:28–31).

The fourth watch of the night — roughly between three and six in the morning (the Roman division of the night).

"I am" (Greek egō eimi, Mt 14:27) — words that sound like the divine name from Ex 3:14.

Ps 77:20 — the psalm about God's way through the sea and the great waters.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Jesus walks on the lake, Simon sinks	Scripture — Mt 14:22–33
The fourth watch of the night	History — the Roman division of the night

The boat holds without the builder	STORY — an image of this book
The boat from chapter 1 as the one in which the twelve sit	STORY — an image of this book

9 · The kingdom is within you

Story

The Pharisees came to ask the way those ask who want to catch someone in his words: "When will the kingdom of God come?"

They stood on the shore where the boat was tied. The carpenter looked at them and at the water behind them and answered not the question but what stood behind it.

"The kingdom of God does not come in a way that can be observed. Nobody will say: Look, here it is, or: Look, there it is. The kingdom of God is within you. And it is also among you, whenever you sit in one boat."

The Pharisees went away dissatisfied, the way people go who look for the kingdom in dates and calendars. But the disciples stayed by the boat, and Simon asked what all of them had been asking silently since Nazareth: "Master, that boat. What is it actually called? You never gave it a name."

The carpenter laid his palms on the side of the hull, on the place where builders carve names.

"It has had one since the first plank. I was only waiting until you could hear it."

And he said: "The kingdom of the heart."

The boat was not built for the lake. The lake was the first water it sailed on. It sailed elsewhere: there where no map reaches and everything reaches. Inward. To the place where storms rise in a person and where there is silence when they calm.

"Everyone has his boat," he said. "I am building the one that will carry people together. Hence kingdom: because in it nobody is alone. And hence heart: because that is where the helm sits."

The kingdom will not come with a calendar.
It is within you
and it is among you,
whenever you sit in one boat.

From Scripture and tradition

Lk 17:20–21 — the Greek entos hymōn means both "within you" and "among you, in your midst". Translations divide; the book holds both.

Jer 31:33; Ezek 36:26; 2 Cor 3:3 — the new covenant written on the heart, not on stone tablets.

Lk 6:45 — out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The answer to the Pharisees about the kingdom	Scripture — Lk 17:20–21 (both the "within" and the "among" readings are possible)
The heart as the place of the new covenant	Scripture — Jer 31:33; Ezek 36:26; 2 Cor 3:3
The name of the boat "the kingdom of the heart"	STORY — derived from Lk 17:21
The boat sails inward	STORY — an image of this book

10 · The child in the middle

Story

On the way the disciples quarrelled. They did not say it aloud, but the carpenter heard it: it was about the benches. Who sits closer to the stern? Who has more work? Who is more? Twelve benches were divided fairly, and yet a man could still argue about which of them was nearest the cushion.

In Capernaum, in the house where they spent the night, he asked: "What were you discussing on the way?" They were silent.

He sat down, called the twelve and said: "Whoever wants to be first, let him be last of all and servant of all."

Then he looked around the room. A child stood by the door. A fisherman's or a neighbour's, the gospels do not say. Nobody had called it. It simply stood and looked.

The carpenter took it by the hand, stood it in the middle and embraced it.

"Whoever receives one such child in my name receives me," he said. "And whoever receives me receives not only me, but the one who sent me."

Nobody said anything. Matthew stopped counting.

The next morning the child came after them as far as the boat, and nobody drove it away. It sat down in the middle, between the benches, on the coiled rope, where no one belonged. Nobody there was first and nobody last. The boat pushed off and the child stretched out its arm and pointed ahead, where the mist was drawing back into the west. It said nothing.

The carpenter looked where the child was pointing and said: "There."

And the boat turned.

Whoever wants to be first, let him sit in the middle.
A child points a finger.
The boat turns.

From Scripture and tradition

Mk 9:33–37; Mt 18:1–5; Lk 9:46–48 — the dispute about who is the greatest, and the child placed in the middle.

Mk 10:13–16 — "Let the children come to me" (own translation).

Mt 18:3 — whoever does not become like children will not enter the kingdom.

A later legend identifies the child with Ignatius of Antioch; the book does not name it.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The dispute about the greatest, the child in the middle	Scripture — Mk 9:33–37
"Let the children come"	Scripture — Mk 10:14
The quarrel about the benches in the boat, the child sits in the middle	STORY — an image of this book
The child points the direction and the boat turns	STORY — an image of this book

11 · The greatest storm

Story

In Jerusalem the air thickened as before a storm. The carpenter knew it. He told the disciples three times and they would not believe him, because people do not believe that the boat they know can go into the deep.

Long before that he had told those who asked for a sign that only one would be given them: the sign of Jonah. As Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so he would be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.

The last supper came: a table, bread, wine and a boat made ready for the night, in the middle of the city, far from water. Then the garden, where he sweated like one who feels every wave before it comes. Then a storm such as had never been there: the kiss of betrayal, silence before judges, hands that only yesterday had held bread. Simon, who once walked on the water, denied three times that he knew him. The cock crowed and the carpenter turned to him. Simon went out and wept bitterly.

Then came wood of another kind. Not a boat, but a beam.

The carpenter who made yokes so that they would not press carried a yoke that could not but press. He hung on wood that he understood better than anyone around him. And then there were no more words. There were three hours of darkness in the middle of the day and a voice that called out: "It is finished."

Joseph of Arimathea laid him in a new tomb cut in the rock, and a stone was rolled against the entrance.

The boat stood in Capernaum, drawn up on the shore, and nobody dared go near it. The twelve benches were empty, the cushion lay on the stern and the wind played with it. It was the sabbath, the day on which one must not work, not on the boat, not on the grave, not on grief.

No boat ever sailed as deep as the one who built it.
He built it for a storm.
And this was that storm.

From Scripture and tradition

Mt 12:38–40; Jon 1:17 — the sign of Jonah: three days and three nights "in the heart of the earth" (Mt 12:40).

Mk 14–15; Lk 22–23; Jn 18–19 — the last supper, the garden, the trial and the crucifixion; Simon's denial (Lk 22:54–62).

Jn 19:30 — "It is finished."

Mk 15:42–47; Jn 19:38–42 — Joseph of Arimathea, the burial, the stone.

Gal 3:13; Deut 21:23 — the wood of the cross. Early church tradition also reads the cross as the mast of the church's ship (for instance Hippolytus).

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The sign of Jonah, "in the heart of the earth"	Scripture — Mt 12:40
The last supper, the garden, the denial, the crucifixion, the burial	Scripture — the passion gospels

The wood of the cross beside the wood of the boat

Tradition — the cross as mast (to be verified)

The empty boat drawn up on the shore, the cushion on the stern

STORY — an image of this book

12 · Three Marys

Story

Mary, in Hebrew Mirjam, was then one of the commonest women's names in the land. Every village had several and nobody thought twice about it. But that day on Golgotha three remained. The men from the boat ran. Three Marys stood still.

The first was the mother. She who once laid her palm on the keel and said nothing. Now she had nothing to say and nothing to lay down. She stood. Nobody called her away and nobody could move her.

The second was from Magdala, from the town by the water that smelled of salt, because lake fish were made into stores there for the whole land. She had followed the carpenter from the moment he gave her back to herself, and from then on she never left him alone, not even where loneliness could not be borne.

The third was Mary of Clopas. The gospels say nothing about her except that she stood there. And perhaps that is precisely why she is here: so that it is clear that not only those of whom stories are told stand by the cross.

They said nothing to one another. They were silent the way people are silent who have already said everything.

On the third day, before dawn, two of them rose. Mary of Magdala and the other Mary went to the tomb. They carried fragrant oils and the question of who would roll away the stone for them. The stone was rolled away. And a sentence was heard that the people from the boat remembered from the lake: "Do not be afraid."

There is an old legend. In Provence they have told it since the Middle Ages. It says that when persecution rose in Jerusalem after Jesus's departure, enemies put several of his friends out to sea in a boat without sails and without oars: Mary of James, Mary called Salome and their servant Sara. Nobody expected them to survive. But the sea did not drown them. It carried them for whole weeks, until a low sandy shore appeared in the mist. Today it is called Saintes-Maries-de-la-Mer, the Holy Marys of the Sea.

In different tellings there are two of those Marys, sometimes three, and sometimes the Magdalene is added to them. The book does not argue about the number. It asks something else: what do you sail with when a boat has no sails?

The carpenter of Nazareth thought about that. That is why he did not sew a sail. And those who stood under the cross knew what sails are sewn from. Not from linen. They are sewn from what remains to a person when he loses everything: from faithfulness.

The book does not claim that it was the boat from the Nazareth workshop. It says only that it had the same name.

They stood when the others ran.
They came first, when it was dawning.
Whoever sails like this needs no sail:
the wind will find him by itself.

From Scripture and tradition

Jn 19:25 — by the cross stood Jesus's mother, her sister Mary of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene. The "three Marys" reading is usual but not the only possible one: some interpreters see four women

there (the mother's sister would then be Salome, cf. Mk 15:40).

Mk 15:40–41; 16:1–4 — the women watch the crucifixion, in the morning they carry fragrant oils and ask who will roll away the stone for them.

Mt 28:1–10 — Mary Magdalene and the other Mary come to the tomb; "Do not be afraid" is heard. Eastern tradition calls Mary Magdalene "equal to the apostles", and Hippolytus around 235 called her "apostle of the apostles".

Lk 8:2 — Mary called Magdalene, from whom seven evil spirits had gone out.

Magdala — a small fishing town on the western shore of the lake (Hebrew migdal, "tower"), in Greek Tarichea (from the word for pickled, salted fish).

The legend of Saintes-Maries-de-la-Mer — a Provençal tradition developed from the Middle Ages. The tellings differ in the number and names of the women. Every May Roma travel to the sea and carry out the statue of Sara.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Three women stand by the cross	Scripture — Jn 19:25 (the "three Marys" reading is usual, not the only one)
Two Marys go to the tomb at dawn, "Do not be afraid"	Scripture — Mt 28:1–10
Magdala as a town of salted fish	History — to be verified before print
The boat without sails, the shore of Provence	Legend — the tellings differ

The mother's palm on the keel, silence under the cross	STORY — an image of this book
The carpenter did not sew a sail, so that those who believe should sail	STORY — an image of this book
That the legendary boat had the same name as the carpenter's boat	STORY — the book does not claim it as fact

13 · The road to Emmaus

Story

The same day that the two Marys found the empty tomb, two men walked from Jerusalem to a village called Emmaus. It was two or three hours' journey. They walked slowly, the way people walk who have nowhere to hurry, because what they had hurried to was over.

One was called Cleopas. The name of the other the gospel did not record. They talked of everything that had happened, and the more they talked of it the more it hurt.

A third caught them up. He walked in the same direction, as slowly, and asked: "What are you discussing on the way, that you are so sad?"

Cleopas stopped. "Are you the only one in Jerusalem who does not know what happened there in these days?"

"What happened?"

And they told him: about the carpenter of Nazareth, who was mighty in word and deed, about how they handed him over and crucified him. "We had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel. And it is already the third day. And this morning some women frightened us: they were at the tomb and did not find the body."

The stranger walked on and spoke. He expounded the whole of Scripture to them, from Moses to the prophets, and showed that everything that had happened had been written. None of them afterwards said that the road had grown shorter. And yet it grew shorter.

When they came to Emmaus he made as if to go further. But they

held him back. "Stay with us. The day is nearly over."

Why did they say it? Perhaps out of respect. Perhaps out of loneliness. Or out of the oldest custom they knew from every house in the land: whoever comes at evening receives bread and salt, and nobody asks him where he is from. He went in.

They sat down at the table. He took bread, blessed it, broke it and gave it to them. And then their eyes were opened. They recognised him. And at that moment he vanished.

For a long time they said nothing. Then one said: "Was not our heart burning while he spoke with us on the road and expounded the Scriptures to us?"

They left the supper standing, rose and went back to Jerusalem, even though it was dark. For the first time in their lives they did not walk slowly.

The heart burned before the eyes recognised.
The eyes recognised at the bread.
The road was the same. They walked differently.

From Scripture and tradition

Lk 24:13–35 — the road to Emmaus. Cleopas is named (24:18), the second disciple is not. Luke gives the distance as sixty stadia, about 11 km; the manuscripts differ and the location of Emmaus is not determined with certainty.

Lk 24:32 — "Was not our heart burning…?" (own translation); the heart that burns recognises before the eyes.

Lk 24:30–31 — he took, blessed, broke, gave: the same sequence of

gestures as at the feeding (Lk 9:16) and at the last supper (Lk 22:19).

The road to Emmaus is in tradition an image of the pilgrim; the pilgrimage along the Camino is read in just the same way.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The road to Emmaus, the unknown companion, the expounding of Scripture, the breaking of bread	Scripture — Lk 24:13–35
"Was not our heart burning?"	Scripture — Lk 24:32
Bread and salt as the custom of hospitality that makes them stop	STORY — a link to chapter 1
For the first time they did not walk slowly	STORY — an addition

14 · The closed doors

Story

In the evening of that day the disciples were together behind closed doors, because they were afraid. The doors had a bar. In the workshop in Nazareth doors were such that they kept the wind outside and the warmth within. These kept the light outside and let fear grow within.

In the middle of the room someone suddenly appeared, for whom no one needed to open. "Peace be with you," he said.

He showed them his hands and his side. They rejoiced, even though they were still trembling. He repeated: "Peace be with you. As the Father sent me, so I send you." And he breathed on them: "Receive the Spirit."

One of the twelve was not there. Thomas, who wanted to see. When he returned, they told him: "We have seen the Lord."

"Unless I see the marks of the nails in his hands and put my finger into them and my hand into his side, I will not believe," he said. It was not proud resistance. It was the hunger of a man who had measured all his life and did not want someone to cheat him now, on the most important thing of all.

Eight days later they were together again and Thomas with them. The doors were closed. And he was there again. "Peace be with you." He turned to Thomas: "Put your finger here and look at my hands. Put out your hand and place it in my side. And do not be unbelieving, but believing."

The gospel does not tell whether Thomas touched. It tells only what

he said: "My Lord and my God."

And the carpenter said: "You have believed because you have seen. Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed."

In the evening Thomas went out into the courtyard. The doors behind him stayed open.

Doors are closed by fear.
Peace passes through closed ones.
Who wanted to see may see.

From Scripture and tradition

Jn 20:19–29 — the appearance behind closed doors and Thomas. "Peace be with you" is the Hebrew greeting shalom. John recalls Thomas's other name Didymus, "twin" (20:24).

Jn 11:16; 14:5 — earlier scenes with Thomas: his willingness to go with Jesus even to death, and the question "how can we know the way?".

Mk 9:50 — "live together in peace" (chapter 4): salt and peace belong together.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The closed doors, "Peace be with you", Thomas, "My Lord and my God"	Scripture — Jn 20:19–29
Thomas, "who wanted to see"	Scripture — Jn 20:25; chapter 5 grows out of this role
The doors of the workshop against the closed doors	STORY — a link to chapter 1

Thomas goes out into the courtyard and leaves the doors open

STORY — an addition

15 · Fire on the shore

Story

After everything that had happened, Simon went back to what he knew. "I am going fishing," he said to the others. "We will go with you," they said.

They got into the boat. There were seven of them and the boat had twelve benches, so five stayed empty. The cushion on the stern stayed empty too.

All night they caught nothing. Again.

At dawn someone stood on the shore. "Children," he called, "have you anything to eat?"

"We have not."

"Let down the net on the right side of the boat."

They let it down and the net was so full that they could not pull it in. John said to Simon: "It is the Lord." Simon girded himself and jumped into the water. The others dragged the boat and the full net to the shore: a hundred and fifty-three large fish. And the net did not tear.

On the shore a charcoal fire was burning. A fish lay on it and beside it bread. Someone had salted it the way one salts for guests who, after a long night, need to be given an appetite.

"Come and eat," he said.

Nobody dared ask who he was, because they all knew.

When they had eaten, he turned to Simon. "Simon, do you love me?"

"Lord, you know that I am your friend."

"Feed my lambs."

He asked a second time and Simon answered the same. He asked a third time and Simon was grieved, because he remembered the cock, and said: "Lord, you know everything. You know that I am your friend."

"Feed my sheep," said the carpenter. "And follow me."

Simon looked back at the boat. It was empty, smooth, weathered. Twelve benches, a cushion on the stern. And he knew that the boat was no longer his. It belonged to those who would come after him.

Three times he denied,
three times he was asked:
do you love me?
And this time the net did not tear.

From Scripture and tradition

Jn 21:1–19 — the appearance by the lake, the full net, the fire on the shore, the breakfast, the threefold question. John alone mentions the 153 fish and that the net did not tear (21:11).

Lk 5:6 — at the first catch the nets were tearing; the contrast with Jn 21:11.

Jn 18:17–27 — Simon's threefold denial, against which stands the threefold question.

The number 153 is interpreted variously in tradition; the book leaves it without interpretation.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The appearance by the lake, the full net, the fire, bread and fish, the threefold question	Scripture — Jn 21:1–19
153 fish and the net did not tear	Scripture — Jn 21:11
Empty benches and an empty cushion	STORY — from chapters 5 and 6
Salted fish on the fire	STORY — an addition

16 · Navicella

Story

When the carpenter vanished from sight, the boat remained. And the people who sailed in it began to call it theirs. They had no harbour; they sailed from town to town and from house to house and everywhere carried the news that the one who built the boat lives.

The first captain was the fisherman Simon, who was called Rock. On the day when fire sounded and everyone understood everyone, thousands of people came aboard at once. And from that time the boat sailed: sometimes under the sails of the wind, sometimes on the oars of tears.

It sailed under emperors who wanted to sink it, and it survived. It sailed through the catacombs and came out. It sailed when the emperors stopped persecuting it and began to admire it, and that was a harder test: a boat that is too large has a helmsman who forgets that a carpenter built it and thinks an empire did.

It shattered into parts and each part claimed to be the whole boat. It took in water through human pride, it cracked at the seams, in the hold they quarrelled and on deck they forgot why it sailed. And yet it sailed. It sailed through the centuries, and in every century someone rediscovered that the anchor is not on board. The anchor is let down upwards, as the author of the letter to the Hebrews wrote: hope is an anchor of the soul that reaches beyond the curtain.

People called it different things: navicella, little ship, ark, church. But on its keel, there where nobody sees, the name the carpenter had given it was still carved: the kingdom of the heart.

And whenever it was most at risk, whenever the crew forgot why it sailed, someone came from behind. Francis, who preached to the birds. A nun who gave herself to the poorest. Grandmothers who secretly taught their grandchildren to pray when it was forbidden. None of them needed to know that they were the captain. They said only one thing: remember the name.

The boat in which they quarrel.
The boat that takes in water.
The boat that sails.

From Scripture and tradition

Heb 6:19–20 — hope as an anchor of the soul that reaches "beyond the curtain", where Jesus entered. The image of an anchor let down upwards is an interpretation of this verse.

Mt 16:18 — "on this rock" (Peter means rock). The interpretation of the words differs among churches.

Acts 2 — Pentecost, "tongues as of fire".

Navicella — Latin for "little ship". The church as a ship has been an image since early Christianity (Tertullian around 200, On Baptism 12); the Latin navis, ship, lives on in the nave of a church. The Florentine painter Giotto made around 1300 in Rome the mosaic Navicella, with the apostles' boat in the storm (Mt 14).

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Pentecost, Simon as the first captain	Scripture — Acts 2; Mt 16:18 (interpretation differs among churches)

The anchor of the soul	Scripture — Heb 6:19–20
The church as a ship, navicella	Tradition — from the 2nd–3rd century
The history of the church compressed into an image	History — compressed
Grandmothers who secretly taught prayer	STORY — a generalising image

17 · A new heaven and a new earth

Story

At the end of the Bible stands a book called Revelation, and at its end stands a harbour.

John, an old prisoner on the island of Patmos, saw it in a vision: a new heaven and a new earth. And there was no longer any sea. Not because it had raged and dried up. The sea, which in his time meant chaos and the fear of the deep, was calmed so that it need not be named. Before the throne lay a sea of glass, like crystal.

And the harbour came down to them. The new Jerusalem, as John wrote, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. And a voice from the throne said: "Behold, the dwelling of God is among men! He will dwell with them and wipe every tear from their eyes. Death will be no more, nor mourning, nor pain. The former things have passed away."

The boat arrived. The boat that carried people through all storms lay in a harbour where there would never again be a storm. Nobody had to sail, there was nowhere to go. But nobody left that boat to rot. They drew it up on land and set it in the middle of the city, in the square where people from all lands gathered, and children climbed on it the way one climbs an old tree.

It was smooth from palms. From the carpenter's palms, from the palms of the twelve, from the palms of the thousands who came after them. The chisels in the workshop in Nazareth were once smooth from three generations. This boat was smooth from all of them.

And John saw a multitude that no sea could swallow: a hundred and forty-four thousand, a number that is both a number and a promise, and behind them a multitude so great that nobody could count it. They stood in white robes with palms in their hands. Through the middle of the city ran a river of the water of life, and on both banks grew the tree of life, which bears fruit twelve times and whose leaves serve for the healing of the nations.

"Behold, I make all things new," said the one who sat on the throne.

And in the middle stood the carpenter, and his boat was no longer one. There were as many of them as there were hearts that had set out on the way.

There was no longer any sea.
The boat, smooth from palms,
stood in the square like a tool after good work.

From Scripture and tradition

Rev 21:1–5 — a new heaven and a new earth, no longer any sea, God dwells with men, he wipes every tear, "I make all things new".

Rev 4:6; 15:2 — the sea of glass, like crystal, before the throne.

Rev 22:1–5 — the river of the water of life and the tree of life; leaves for the healing of the nations.

Rev 7:4–9; 14:1 — a hundred and forty-four thousand sealed (a symbolic number, 12 × 12 × 1000) and an innumerable multitude.

The sea means in Old Testament and apocalyptic language chaos and hostile power (for instance Dan 7:2–3; Rev 13:1). Its disappearance means the end of chaos, not the loss of beauty.

Tradition places John as an exile on the island of Patmos (Rev 1:9).

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
A new heaven and a new earth, no longer any sea, the new Jerusalem	Scripture — Rev 21:1–5
The sea of glass; 144,000 and the innumerable multitude	Scripture — Rev 4:6; 7:4–9
The river and the tree of life	Scripture — Rev 22:1–5
The boat in the square, smooth from palms	STORY — an image of this book
"As many boats as hearts"	STORY — an image of this book

PART II · CEDAR

This part too belongs to the ZION telling. It follows on from the series The Salt of This Earth, from the Book of Lumi and from the book Nirvana, and it follows a single trunk of cedar from the workshop in Nazareth to the threshold of a new house. It is marked as a story; the facts about the network are not in it.

18 · The city without taste

Story

The city was called Bezechuti, though it never wanted to be so named. Once it had been a city like any other: the markets smelled of cumin and fresh bread, children laughed in the courtyards and by the fountain old women told each other who had once managed to survive a famine. Then the merchants grew rich, the king built higher walls, and the food sold in the markets began to taste different. Not worse. Different. The bread was white and soft and had no taste. The wine was old and expensive and had no taste. Promises were long and considered and had no taste.

One evening, when the sun was setting behind the walls like a coal doused with water, a man from Galilee came into the city. He was not a king nor a scholar nor a general. He was a carpenter. Behind him he dragged a two-wheeled cart covered with a cloth of coarse linen, and in his bag he carried a clay cup of coarse salt.

He sat down under an old fig tree at the edge of the market, where those gathered whom no inn would take inside: water-carriers, soldiers without pay, women who had buried more children than they had raised. He left the cart standing a little apart, the cloth tied fast. He set the cup on the ground among them.

"And what is that for?" asked one of the carriers. "That is only salt. We are hungry, not in need of salt."

"Try your bread without it," said the carpenter.

The old soldier with the scarred hand dipped a piece of flatbread into the salt, bit into it and was silent a while. "It tastes different," he

said at last. As if he remembered a taste he had lost without noticing when.

"You are the salt of the earth," said the carpenter quietly, not as a sermon but as an observation he had been allowed to say aloud. "Not a king, not a general. You, whom the city forgets until it needs you, give taste to everything else."

"And what if salt loses its taste?" asked the woman who had buried three children and still carried water to the well, because it was the only thing she could do for the living.

"Then it is good for nothing," he answered. "That is not a punishment. It is a description. Salt that stops doing the one thing it is for is only dust."

None of them grew rich that night. But when they parted in the morning, each carried a handful of coarse salt in his pocket: the carrier to the well, the soldier to the gate, the woman to the neighbours' children she helped, because she no longer had her own.

The cloth on the cart did not move. Only when it had truly grown dark and there remained in the square only one old man who had stood there since morning and did not know why, did the carpenter untie one corner and draw the covering back a little. The old man looked. Under the cloth lay a long beam of cedar wood, smooth and dark, in one place so polished as if someone had been laying a palm on it for many years. It smelled the way things smell that have waited a long time.

"What is that?" asked the old man.

"A keel," said the carpenter. "It is waiting for a boat."

"And where is the boat?"

"There is none yet," said the carpenter. "But there is already someone for it."

Salt does not need a great city.
A handful is enough, and someone to give it away.
And under the cloth a keel is waiting.

From the ZION telling

The Salt of This Earth, episodes 1 and 2 — the city of Bezechuti, the carpenter with the clay cup of salt and the conversation under the fig tree. The book retells them briefly and adds one thing: the keel under the cloth. The series itself says that its characters are archetypes and not history.

Mt 5:13 — the words about salt, see chapter 4.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The city of Bezechuti, the clay cup, the conversation under the fig tree	ZION telling — The Salt of This Earth, ep. 1 (MYTH)
"You are the salt of the earth"	Scripture — Mt 5:13
The keel under the cloth on the cart, the smooth place from a palm	STORY — an image of this book
That the carpenter of Bezechuti is the carpenter of chapters 1–17	STORY — the book claims it as an image, not as history

19 · The keel in the cloth

Story

The man who came to Bezechuti last was not young. He carried the dust of a long journey on him and in his eyes had the strange mixture of weariness and certainty that people have to whom something has been said that nobody else believes, and who nonetheless did not stop doing it. He was called Noah.

By the fire under the fig tree, where more people now gathered than on the first night, he said: "I come with a different message than the others. The water that is sung about will come, more than you expect. And a boat will be needed."

"What water?" asked the soldier, and his hand slipped to the place where he once carried a sword.

"Not a punishment," said Noah quickly. "Physics. A world overloaded with too many promises without taste and too many contracts without salt will one day overflow. I was warned not because I am better than others. I was warned because I was willing to build before it began to rain."

The water-carrier frowned. "What would we build it from?"

The carpenter stood up. "We have wood," he said.

He went to the cart, untied the rope and drew the cloth right off. The keel lay in the firelight and they all looked at it like a thing they had not known they were missing.

"I have been building it since my youth," said the carpenter. "From a single trunk. I did not sell it because I did not know for whom. Now I know."

Noah passed his palm along the keel from bow to stern and stopped at one place. The wood there was smoother than anywhere else. "Someone laid a hand here."

"My mother," said the carpenter.

Noah said nothing. He only nodded and took his hand away.

They built the boat around the keel, the way a boat is built that is to hold: slowly, laying every plank three times. Sita, who had been kneading clay from the fountain all day, made the first firm deck out of it. Hanuman cleared the great stones from the blocked channel so that the water could run off where it belonged. The smith, who had lost his workshop in a fire, forged the bolts. The farmer from the surrounding fields brought pitch. The ark was larger than the boat from Nazareth. But the keel beneath it was the same. And they made one door. Not one for kings and one for the poor, but a single entrance through which anyone could come in who decided to come in before it began to rain.

On the last evening, when the whole boat already stood on the keel, a woman came to the fire. She wore a simple dress the colour of the evening sky, had a drop of sandalwood on her forehead and a bamboo flute in her hand. Her name was Radha.

"You are building a beautiful boat," she said, and sat down on a stone directly opposite the carpenter. "You have firm joints and exact angles and a door that is the same for all. But who will sing on it? Who will dance on the deck when night comes?"

Nobody answered. The carpenter looked at her for a long time. Then he rose, went to the stern and straightened the cushion of coarse

cloth there.

"This place is free," he said. "I thought it was for the one who sleeps when it seems to the others that everything is perishing. Perhaps it is also for the one who sings."

Radha smiled, stepped onto the boat, sat down on the cushion and played. And then for the first time they understood that the cushion on the stern is not a place for the builder. It is a place for the one who is not afraid.

On the underside of the keel, there where nobody sees, a name was carved. Nobody read it aloud. Nobody needed to.

The boat is built around what was waiting.
On the stern is a place for the one who is not afraid.
The name is carved below.

From the ZION telling

The Salt of This Earth, episode 5 (The Ark) — Noah, one door, Sita with clay, Hanuman with stones.

The Salt of This Earth, episode 9 — Radha with the flute and the question "who will sing on that boat?".

Gen 6:14 — the building of the ark, see chapter 2.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The ark in Bezechuti, Noah, one door, Sita, Hanuman	ZION telling — The Salt of This Earth, ep. 5 (MYTH)
Radha, the flute, the question "who will sing?"	ZION telling — ep. 9 (MYTH)

The ark built around the keel from Nazareth, the trace of the mother's palm	STORY — an image of this book
The cushion on the stern as the place for the one who is not afraid	STORY — an image of this book

20 · The first ray

Story

Then the water came. It did not come as a punishment, as Noah had said, but as physics: slowly, from all sides, until it was not clear where the land ended and where what carried it began. The ark sailed. It had one hearth, a bowl of salt on the table, a few dozen beams and a keel of a single trunk of cedar.

The water fell so slowly that nobody counted the days any more. In the hold the beams creaked and people spoke quietly, as if a louder word could break something. Some whispered that there was no shore.

Between the third and the fourth watch, when the darkness is thickest, a child stood at the narrow opening in the bow. Barefoot, small, with hair as light as foam on the edge of a wave. It did not pull anyone by the sleeve. It only raised its hand and pointed its finger into the mist.

The carpenter, who was just then checking the bolts of the helm, stopped and looked where the child was pointing. It was there: a thin golden-blue band of light that came neither from lightning nor from burning sulphur. It did not shine on land and it did not shine on trees. But it was there, calm and undeniable.

The child was called Elizabeth, after her grandmother. From that morning they called her on the ark Lumi, after the light she showed before anyone else.

The carpenter did not sleep that night. He took a piece of cedar left over from repairing a seam in the keel, from the same trunk the keel

was from, and a shard of thick glass from a broken ship's lamp. By morning he had carved and joined from them a small lantern. It was not beautiful. It was firm.

"Empty," said Lumi when he handed it to her in the morning.

"For now."

He turned it so that the glass caught that band from the mist. The light broke in it, lingered and stayed: a small, steady flame that needed no oil.

"It will not show you the way," said the carpenter. "For that there are stars and eyes. It will show you two things: what is, and what could be. And your work will be never to confuse them."

Lumi raised the lantern. The glass was warm. Under her feet the keel sounded quietly. It had been built for those who would one day need it, and one of them was the child now standing in the bow. The cedar that had once heard a voice from the boat on the lake now heard a child. And the boat held.

First you do not see the shore.
You see only a thin ray.
And that is enough.

From the ZION telling

Nirvana, episodes 1 and 2 — the ark after the flood, the child Lumi in the bow, the first ray, the mountain of Ararat.

The Book of Lumi, chapter 1 — the lantern from a cedar offcut and a shard of ship's lamp, the flame that distinguishes what is from what could be.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The flood, the ark, the child in the bow, the first ray	ZION telling — Nirvana ep. 1; Lumi 1 (MYTH)
The lantern from cedar and a shard of ship's lamp	ZION telling — Lumi 1 (MYTH)
The offcut is from the same trunk as the keel from Nazareth	STORY — an image of this book
The child is Elizabeth, after her grandmother	ZION telling — Lumi 1 (MYTH)

21 · The house with doors without a lock

Story

After many weeks of sailing after the ray, the hull of the ark scraped against a rock. It was not a shipwreck. It was the slow and firm settling of a heavy keel into a bed of stone. The boat rocked, groaned in all its timbers and for the first time in months stopped. Silence came.

The mist parted and before them rose a bare rock that emerged from the retreating water like a lighthouse carved by the land itself. They named it Ararat. One could not live on it, it was too steep and stony, but one could light on it the first fire that the wind would not blow out. And from its summit they saw in the west a land: green plains, old forests untouched by the axe of greed, torrents and bays with white sand. There were no barriers on it and no customs houses. They named it Terra Nova.

On the first slope they built a house. The foundations they cut from basalt which they brought from Ararat, and the beams from cedars saved from the ark. The longest beam, the one on which the whole roof was to rest, the carpenter took from the keel.

Nobody asked him whether he meant it. The keel that waited for a boat and became a boat was now becoming a threshold. When he cut it, he stopped the saw over the place where the wood was smoothest. He held his hand there a long time. Then he said only: "Not here," and cut elsewhere. He left the smooth place on the inner side of the beam beside the hearth, where the hand of everyone who enters can reach it. And whoever entered laid a palm on it without knowing why.

The beam that became the lintel over the door had a name carved on its underside. What had once waited in the dark beneath the boat was now above the head of everyone who came in. Beside the name the carpenter carved a golden ray crossing a wave.

On that first night a woman came to the threshold in a green dress with a wreath of wild flowers. Her name was Sita. She did not sit down by the fire. She knelt where the floor of cedar beams ended and the bare clay of the new land began, and took into one palm a handful of salt from the table and into the other a handful of earth from the threshold.

"Salt protects what already is," she said. "Seed makes what is not yet. A covenant that is to survive a flood needs both."

The carpenter looked into the fire for a long time. Then he took the chisel and beside the name carved a small seed with a root. "So that nobody can rewrite it, when we forget why we promised it."

The house had a single large room, a stone hearth, a long bench and an oak table. Onto the table the carpenter poured into a bowl the salt from his clay cup. Salt from the lake on which one had once learned from a boat. The pilgrims tasted it and nobody spoke.

The doors were wide, forged, without a bar and without a keyhole. Whoever came at night did not have to knock or prove where he was from. It was enough to push.

"And when a thief comes?" asked Lumi.

"What would he steal?" said the carpenter. "The house has nothing. What has value, each carries with him."

He set the empty cup on the shelf above the hearth.

"Why does it stand there?" asked Lumi.

"For the next one," he said. "So that there is somewhere to pour salt for whoever comes with another handful."

The keel became a threshold.
The name from the bottom of the boat is above the door.
And the doors have no lock.

From the ZION telling

Nirvana, episodes 2–4 — Ararat, Terra Nova, the House of Lumi of basalt and cedar, doors without a bar, a bowl of salt on the table.

The Book of the Earth, chapter 1 — Sita with salt and seed, the seed carved above the door.

The Book of Lumi, chapter 2 — doors without a lock.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Ararat, Terra Nova, the House of Lumi, doors without a bar, salt on the table	ZION telling — Nirvana ep. 2–4; Lumi 2 (MYTH)
The golden ray crossing a wave and the seed above the door	ZION telling — Nirvana ep. 4; Bodhi Gaia 1 (MYTH)
The roof beam cut from the keel, the name above the door, the smooth place from a palm	STORY — an image of this book
Salt from the cup in the bowl, the empty cup on the shelf	STORY — an image of this book

22 · The lantern shows today

Story

The pilgrim told the story up to the moment when the keel became a threshold. There he stopped.

The sun was high above the gate and Radha had long since given salt to all who came in the night. Lumi slept leaning against the stone. Elizabeth stood by the pillar with the lantern and did not look tired.

"And what next?" she asked. "The keel is a threshold, the offcut is a lantern, the name is above the door. What of it has remained?"

"Plans," said the pilgrim. "A house that stands, and a boat that is not."

"Then let us look," said Elizabeth, and raised the lantern.

The light narrowed and the pilgrim saw what actually is. He saw four drawings. Two were hulls, on the third there was only a line of horizon with one star, and the fourth, much larger, showed four decks with a note: a study, not a production plan. He saw a table with papers, and at the table people calculating what the boats would cost and who would be allowed to sail them. He saw that no keel is laid. He saw sails of which nobody yet knows whether they will carry the wind. And he saw an honest word written in pencil above the plans: proposal.

"It is a proposal," he said.

"Proposal is an honest word for a boat that is not yet," said Elizabeth. "But notice that the word does not say never."

Then the light widened and the pilgrim saw what could be. He

opened his palm, on which the salt from Radha still lay, and began to tell on.

The lantern shows two things:
what is and what could be.
And your work is not to confuse them.

From the ZION telling

The Book of Lumi, chapters 1 and 5 — the lantern that distinguishes what is from what could be; the gate and the two priestesses.

The Book of the Way (María del Camino) — a working concept of the fleet Tres Marías: hulls I and II as a proposal, hull III as a horizon.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The lantern distinguishes what is from what could be	ZION telling — Lumi 1, 5 (MYTH)
The fleet: two hulls as a proposal, the third as a horizon, no keel laid	CONSTRUCTION and HORIZON — according to the Book of the Way
"Proposal is an honest word for a boat that is not yet"	STORY — an image of this book

PART III · THE FLEET

This part belongs to the ZION telling. It is marked because it is different: it is not Scripture or history, but a story and a vision that are added to the carpenter's story. Whoever does not want to read it skips straight to the Epilogue.

23 · The fleet gathers

"I am Maitreya, born of Hiranyagarbha. I was a cowherd with a flute, and a prince in exile, and also a carpenter who built a boat he called the kingdom of the heart."
— a mantra from the book Maitreya

Story

The lantern now showed what could be, and none of it sails yet. There came the time that the old books called the end and the new books call the birth.

Other boats appeared on the water. They were not a miracle. They were built by people who knew the carpenter's story and decided to give it successors: three hulls for three oceans, named after three forms of Mary which the pilgrim on his journey received as visions.

The first, Santa María la Mayor, belongs to the Atlantic. Her home port is Pontevedra in Galicia, where seafarers once built a basilica to their Mary. She wears the robe of a red queen.

The second, Nossa Senhora de Fátima, belongs to the Pacific. She is a solar catamaran modelled on the Polynesian double canoes that read the ocean by waves and stars. Her home is in Te Pīko Ora on Raiatea and she wears a white wedding dress.

The third, María de las Nieves, belongs to the Indian Ocean. She is golden and carries a child. That one does not exist yet. She is a horizon, and a horizon deserves honesty. And beyond her there is a fourth boat, of which one speaks differently. It does not carry pilgrims out, but the way back. It is called the Ark and carries the same name on its keel.

Each of them carries fifteen people: twelve pilgrims, as many benches as the carpenter's boat had, and two or three of the crew. In the bow of each stands a child in the robe of the colour of its Mary and points ahead. Their sails are of light. Into them are laminated cells that turn sun and wind into current, and beneath the hull turn turbines that recharge the batteries from the voyage. Nobody has yet seen how a sail of light strains in a real wind. It is an intention, a drawing and a hope, and the book says it as it is.

When the keel of each of them is laid, a strip of old cedar from the lintel over the door of the House of Lumi will be set into it, from the wood that once heard a voice from the boat on the Kinneret. Into the strip, by another hand and in another script, the name it already has will be carved. Thus the old keel will meet the new ones. For now it is only an image, because no keel is laid.

The kingdom of the heart.

These three Marys are not the women who stood under the cross. The names repeat, the roads do not get confused. But whoever hears the name Tres Marías, let him remember the boat without sails from the legend. That boat sailed without sails because its passengers were driven out. These boats have sails because someone has reached where no foot reaches. They are not the same boats. One is the answer to the other. And whoever asks what sails are sewn from, let him remember: from faithfulness, and from what is woven into them so that both wind and light can carry them.

The mantra from the book Maitreya joins three figures, the cowherd with the flute, the prince in exile and the carpenter who built a boat, into one voice. It is an image, not a genealogy: the book does not

claim that any of them was born again. The name Maitreya means the one who comes. A Christian may hear in it the expectation of the Lord's coming, a Buddhist the coming of the future Buddha. The book does not decide between them. It says only that all roads that are called the road home sail in the same direction.

Three boats for three oceans.
On the stern a cushion, in the sails light.
No keel is laid yet.
The name is already carved.

From tradition and from the ZION telling

This chapter is not Scripture or history. It is a vision of the ZION project and a literary layer added to the carpenter's story.

Santa María la Mayor — a basilica in Pontevedra, built in the 16th century by the seafarers' guild.

Nossa Senhora de Fátima — Fátima in Portugal, 1917.

María de las Nieves — patroness of the island of La Palma; the feast of the Bajada de la Virgen.

Wa'a kaulua — a Polynesian double sailing canoe.

The legend of the three Marys — see chapter 12.

Maitreya — in Buddhism the future Buddha; in the ZION telling "the one who comes".

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status

Tres Marías: three boats for three oceans	VISION — a working concept of the ZION project
Hulls I and II (Santa María la Mayor, Nossa Senhora de Fátima)	CONSTRUCTION — designed, not built; no keel laid
Hull III (María de las Nieves)	HORIZON — a boat that does not exist yet; beyond it the fourth vessel, the Ark (chapter 27)
Sails of light	CONCEPT — a technology not yet verified in deployment
Pontevedra, Fátima 1917, La Palma	TRADITION — living traditions on which the names stand
The Marian "apparitions" on the pilgrim's road	STORY (myth) — an authorial layer
The strip of cedar from the House of Lumi in the keels of the new boats, the child in the bow	STORY — an image of this book
Maitreya as "the one who comes"	A spiritual reading of the ZION story; not dogma

24 · The chronicler

Story

The lantern showed one more thing that could be: one journey. It belonged to a woman whom nobody ever met, because she did not live. Her name was Lumen, a name like Lumi, but she was different: grown up, a scientist, a person who liked things that could be verified.

She had once entered ZION without great words, only to look. At the gate, where seven roads were offered, she chose the Road of Knowledge and answered the first question inconspicuously: that first of all she wanted to know where those words came from. From then on she carried in her head the question How do I recognise the truth? like a stone in her pocket. The years wore it down until it was smooth, and she touched it whenever she was not sure.

In one possible future, not the one that will come but the one that can be imagined, Lumen stood in April on the quay in Pontevedra with a backpack and a folder. In the folder she had every step since the train from Bohemia, with a date, with an hour and with a photograph of a stamp. She believed that whoever has a record cannot get lost.

Above the bay stood a boat, smaller than she expected. Its hull was painted a dark red, not royal, rather the red of wine that has long lain in a barrel, and above it sails of pale canvas with woven strips of solar fibre. On its side in white letters stood SANTA MARÍA LA MAYOR.

"Are you the chronicler?" asked the woman on the bridge. She was broad-shouldered, around fifty, her hands cracked from ropes, and

she spoke Spanish with a Galician accent. "Inés Varela, captain. We do not sail tomorrow. Tomorrow you work in the garden."

"In the garden?"

"Our boat has a garden. You do not yet know what it is good for."

In the cabin under the bow an embroidered red cloth hung on the wall and beneath it a thin book with stiff covers. Inside there was not a single stamp, not a single name.

"An empty credencial," said Inés. "They say a Pilgrim once left it behind. You may call that a story. I call it a book that is written in only after the journey. Not before it."

The garden lay behind the docks, in a former salt store, where beans, dill, mustard and tomatoes that refused to believe in April grew on terraces. For two days Lumen dug and carried buckets. Her hands hurt differently from fingers on a keyboard, more deeply. On the third day old Xoán came with a spade over his shoulder and looked at what she was writing.

"That I transplanted twenty seedlings. And that the soil in the mustard bed has a pH of seven point two."

"And do you know it, or do you think it?"

"I measured it."

"With what?"

Lumen was silent. She had measured it with strips she found in the cupboard. Nobody had verified them. "The strips are old," she said at last.

Xoán nodded and handed her a handful of earth. "Then write it like

this: pH seven point two according to the old strips, uncertain. That is an honest record. The earth will let you be wrong and will forgive you for it. If you want to know the truth, begin by not being afraid to be mistaken."

That is how the book the pilgrim told at the gate is written too: every sentence with a line where it stands what is stone and what is only an image.

pH seven point two, according to the old strips, uncertain.
That is an honest record.
The earth will let you be wrong.

From the ZION telling

En Camino, chapter I (a literary continuation, DRAFT awaiting cultural review) — Lumen, captain Inés, the garden in the former salt store. The story itself says it is a MYTH, one of the possible future horizons.

The Book of the Way (María del Camino) — Pontevedra as home port, the credencial, the route.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Pontevedra, the seafarers' basilica, the coastal Camino	LIVE — geography and tradition
The boat Santa María la Mayor with sails of light	CONSTRUCTION and HORIZON — the sailing form is only an idea
Lumen, Inés, Xoán, the garden, the empty credencial	STORY (myth) — En Camino I

"An honest record": uncertain, according to the old strips

STORY — a link to the labels of this book

25 · Numbers at sea

Story

They sailed in May and knew the journey would take months, because boats wait for favourable seasonal windows and nobody hurries them. On the way they stopped in the Nabão valley, near Sabacheira, where the Garden of Genesis stood with a small albergue for pilgrims. There Lumen received the first stamp in her credencial, the carimbo of the Garden.

Then they put out onto the Atlantic. The first night was calm. On the second morning the sky turned the colour of lead and the waves began to have a will of their own. The crew took down part of the sails. Lumen sat in the cabin with her feet braced against a locker, seasick and pale, trying to keep the record of supplies, because that was her work and because hands that write somewhat dull nausea.

She added, subtracted, and the numbers did not agree.

She leafed back. On the day of departure she had written in the column drinking water, tank no. 2: 640 litres. According to the handover sheet of the port technician, which she had stuck to the back, only 460 had flowed in then. She had transposed two digits. Since then the rations had been calculated by her number. It came out that tank no. 2 would empty several days earlier than everyone was saying.

The boat rose and fell. Nobody will find out, it occurred to her. It is enough to quietly correct the number, there is enough in tank no. 1, and nothing has happened. The folder stays clean.

But it was precisely the folder that had taught her that a record is a

contract with the people who will rely on it, as the salt on the table is a promise to the guest. And those people were sitting a deck higher, eating soup according to her number.

She climbed the ladder with a burning face and a paper in her hand. Inés stood at the helm, tied on with a rope.

"Captain, there is a mistake of mine in the log. I transposed a number. Tank no. 2 had a hundred and eighty litres less than I stated. We have been calculating the rations from Pontevedra by the wrong number."

Inés looked at her for a long time. "Good. Come below."

In the cabin she stood over the chart and said nothing. Lumen expected an explosion and did not get one.

"Do you know what a bad chronicler would have done? Corrected it in silence. What would an average one do? Admitted it only when something happened. You came earlier. That is not praise. That is a statement. The plan changes: we head for the nearest port where water can be taken on, and that is La Palma. We will not press on to meet the deadline, nor save water to keep it. Lives before the plan."

"And the record?"

"Not a crossing out, an addition. The date of the correction, the original number, the correct number, your name. So that it can be seen that the record can be read and believed. That is the gift I want from you. Not flawlessness. That when you make a mistake, it will be seen."

That night Lumen wrote in the folder the first sentence that was not certain: I was wrong. Here is how.

They reached La Palma at dawn. Nobody invited them into the sanctuary, only into the kitchen, which smelled of cumin and fresh bread, and nobody asked why they were tired. They filled the tanks, repaired a torn sail, and Lumen scraped potatoes for three days. For the first time in her life she accepted help without having to earn it.

Not a crossing out, but an addition.
A record is a contract with those who will read it.
A mistake that can be seen is a gift.

From the ZION telling

En Camino, chapter II (DRAFT) — the record of supplies, the mistake and the captain's answer "lives before the plan".

The Book of the Way — the Garden of Genesis and the albergue near Sabacheira, La Palma as the island of the third apparition.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The Nabão valley, Sabacheira, the island of La Palma	LIVE — geography
The Garden of Genesis with the albergue, the kitchen on La Palma	CONSTRUCTION and HORIZON — in preparation; here only an idea
The mistake in the record, the admission, "lives before the plan"	STORY (myth) — En Camino II
The record as salt on the table, a promise to the guest	STORY — a link to chapters 1 and 4

26 · A sea overland

Story

From La Palma a crossing of the Atlantic awaited the crew. It lasted three weeks. During it Lumen stopped being seasick and began to look: at dolphins, at white birds, at the evening sea that turned the colour of a ripe plum. They landed on the Caribbean side of Costa Rica, where people with long tables awaited them and a question she did not expect.

"What are you carrying, and whose is it?"

Between the two oceans lies land. Boats do not sail across here; one crosses the isthmus overland and the crew carries what it can carry or what its hosts allow it to bring over. No canal runs through Costa Rica, and the old trail Camino de Cruces, which Lumen had read about in winter, lies in Panama, a little further on. Here it was a matter of other paths, worn by other people.

The girl called Marisol, who was in charge of the receiving, spread the boxes from the boat on the table and opened them one by one.

"Seeds. From where?"

"From Sabacheira and from Pontevedra. We received them in exchange."

"Do you have that on paper?"

Lumen had papers for everything, except for one bag from Pontevedra, labelled only with a note: from Xoán, for the other gardens.

"This will not pass," said Marisol calmly. "And if there were more of

the kind, nothing without a document would pass."

"Those are ordinary beans."

"Perhaps. I do not know from whom. I do not know whether that person was allowed to give them on. We suspect nobody here. We only ask."

Lumen felt her ears redden. She wanted to say that it was a bag of beans and that asking about every seed was pedantry. Then she remembered the earth. "I do not have it," she said. "I will write to Xoán. We will wait."

They waited four days. The answer came: the beans are from his sister's field and the sister is glad to give them. Lumen breathed out. Marisol nodded and then refused.

"The origin is explained, that is good. But seeds across borders need more than a sister's goodwill. They need phytosanitary documents and permission for the countries into which you want to bring them. A donor's consent is not a transport permit." She took a small round stamp. "I will write it truthfully. Not passed. Not failed."

Into the protocol she wrote: origin explained, donor's consent documented; transport suspended, permit missing. And she pressed the stamp. Lumen stared at that line for a long time. It was the first record in her life that said neither yes nor no, and yet was exact.

The bag stayed under the control of the receiving office. Only a copy of the record went with her into the Pacific, and the note with the name of the field, a label without a seed. She put it in the folder as the trace of something that did not arrive, and it taught her more than anything that did arrive.

On the last day a long column walked, an old trail over the ridge, with mules and backpacks, with the load divided among all, including those who had never sailed on the boat. Lumen carried a crate of tools. In the evening she wrote in the folder: Relationships are not cargo. She crossed it out, because it sounded like wisdom from a calendar. Then she wrote it again, in smaller letters, because it was true.

Not passed. Not failed.
Origin explained, permit missing.
An exact record is neither yes nor no.

From the ZION telling

En Camino, chapter III (DRAFT) — the receiving on the isthmus, the bag of seeds without a permit.

The Book of the Way, chapter 6 — the handover between the oceans overland.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Carrying seeds across borders requires phytosanitary documents and a permit	LIVE — general rules; here only an illustration
The isthmus, the crossing overland, the handing over of crews and cargo	CONSTRUCTION and HORIZON — a working concept
Camino de Cruces lies in Panama, not in Costa Rica	LIVE — geography and history
Marisol, Xoán, the receiving and the stamp	STORY (myth) — En Camino III

27 · The fourth vessel

"Build yourself a boat. Not because the flood will come, but because one day someone will be in the water."

Story

When the three Marys sailed out to three oceans, there remained on the shore a question that no sail answers. The pilgrims' boats carry those who set out. But who will go back for the person who cannot set out?

The lantern showed the answer too, and it was larger than all the previous ones. It was a fourth drawing: a steel hull about eighty-five metres long, three masts, four decks, a greenhouse and a solar roof on top. Above the plan it was written that this was a study and not a production plan, and that it must be examined by those who understand stability, steel and storms.

It was the same boat, built again. Larger, of steel, with seeds instead of animals and a hundred people instead of eight. And it was called what every boat is called that carries people home: the kingdom of the heart.

It was not a boat for pilgrims. The three Marys carry people there, the ark carries a harbour. It carried a school and a library without internet, a sick bay and a workshop where they can sew their own sail and forge their own part. It carried seeds in the cold, thirty to sixty thousand species and varieties, and on the upper deck it sowed them into soil, so that the archive would not be only a larder but also a garden. And everything on board that mattered was there twice: two who can heal, two who can forge, two who can read the stars.

Like the animals once, only otherwise.

One thing that boat did not do: it did not run away. "The aim is not to get away," it said in the plan. "The aim is to outlast." And that is why it sailed at the side of whales. The humpback feeds in cold waters in summer and gives birth in warm ones in winter and all the time keeps to the shelves where the water is safe. The ark did not sail against the weather, it went with it, after the whale, because the whale knows where the water is safe. Every piece of that circuit ended at one node of the network, so the boat was not a bunker. It was a journey between people.

Long before that, one man lay three days in the belly of a great fish and nobody believed he would survive it. This boat sailed at the side of great fish and nobody was afraid of them.

In the bow stood a child in the fourth robe, which was added to the red, the white and the golden: the colour of the sea. It held the world in its palm and looked into the darkness that the lantern illumines.

"Is it the mother ship of the Marys," asked the pilgrim, "or their sister?"

"Nobody knows yet," said Elizabeth. "No keel is laid. We do not know how much it will cost, who will own it, or where we will put it into the water. We know only whom it is to serve."

"Whom?"

"The one who will be in the water."

When the keel is laid, a strip of cedar from the lintel over the door of the House of Lumi belongs in it too. The carpenter built for those who would one day need it. Now it has become clear who that is: the

one who will be in the water.

Three boats carry pilgrims there.
The fourth carries a harbour.
And it comes back for those who stayed on the shore.

From the ZION telling

The Kingdom of the Heart · Nirvana (the thirteenth node of L5, a page on app.zionterranova.com) — the fourth vessel, study B3, the whale circuit, the seed archive, a colony of up to a hundred people. The page itself says it is a vision, that no keel is laid, and that the parameters must be verified by naval architects.

Mt 12:40; Jon 1:17 — the great fish, see chapter 11.

Gen 6:19–20 — the animals two by two into the ark, see chapter 2.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
The Ark as the fourth vessel and the thirteenth node of L5	VISION — a working study of the ZION project
A steel hull of around 85 m, up to a hundred people, a seed archive, a greenhouse	STUDY — parameters to be verified by naval architects; no keel laid
The route alongside humpbacks between the nodes of the network	VISION — a study, not a promise
The child in the robe the colour of the sea	STORY (myth) — the fourth robe of the series
The Ark as "the same boat, built again"	STORY — an image of the page and of this book
The strip of cedar from the House of Lumi in the keel of the Ark	STORY — an image of this book

28 · The lantern is carried

Story

The pilgrim finished speaking of the fourth boat and fell silent. Lumi woke, stretched and sat down beside him on the stone. She had the lantern on her lap, as she had once held it in the bow. On the other side Elizabeth sat down, so close that their shoulders touched, and the girl and the woman suddenly looked like one person seen at two times.

"And what then?" asked the pilgrim. "When the keel is laid and the boat launched. When we are gone."

"Then a hundred years," said Elizabeth. "As many as the lantern shines ahead."

She handed it to him. It was warm, heavier than it looked, and of cedar that smelled the way things smell that have waited a long time. The pilgrim raised it and the light narrowed.

He saw a child. Six years old, barefoot, by a fire. Those were the years when the boat is small and the most important thing is not to say more than can be verified. The child pointed ahead and nobody forced it to say what it saw.

The lantern went round, from hand to hand, from the pilgrim to Lumi, from Lumi to Elizabeth and from Elizabeth back to him, and at every handing the light narrowed and showed a different age.

He saw a girl on a foreign shore. She was teaching people she had never seen before how to light their own fire, how to read a book and how not to believe it. The boat now sailed for those who never stood on it either. They translated its books into languages the carpenter

did not speak, and they criticised it.

He saw a woman after a storm. The boat will not be saved by being larger, she said, but by being quickly repaired after every blow and by nobody sweeping the cracks under the carpet. One day someone will come with a proposal that would harm the boat, and the crew will say no, and that no will be enough.

He saw a woman of fifty handing over keys. Those who grew up on the boat did not take the carpenter for an authority. They could rewrite what he wrote, or split the boat in two, when they disagreed, and nobody was allowed to tell them that by doing so they had betrayed the story.

He saw an old woman by a fire she had not lit. She listened to people speaking of things that used to be exceptional and now are ordinary: of public proof, of the right to refuse, of care that is not done for show, of a machine that can be repaired. They did not utter the name from which everything began, because they no longer needed it. The old woman did not mind.

And he saw the lantern in hands he did not know. The light in it burned on.

"So I will not get it?" said Lumi quietly. "I will only carry it part of the way?"

"You will get it," said Elizabeth. "But not as an inheritance. As work. An inheritance can be lost. Work can only be done, or not done."

The pilgrim remembered the lintel over the door of the House of Lumi. "The wood will age," he said. "Some generation will replace it. And the name?"

"It will be cut again," said Elizabeth. "The cedar will be replaced, the keel will be replaced, and the name will be carved anew, by another hand and in another script. Only it must not forget where it comes from."

None of it was prophecy. It was a list of what could be, as honest as any list that knows its own blank lines. The pilgrim returned the lantern to Lumi. She raised it and the light showed only what actually was: morning at the gate, salt and three people on a stone.

The lantern is not inherited.
The lantern is carried.
The cedar will be replaced, the name remains.

From the ZION telling

The Book of Lumi, chapter 11 (A Hundred Years of the Lantern) — six ages of the lantern passing from hand to hand. The book itself says it is a scenario of handing over responsibility, not a prophecy.

The Book of Lumi, chapter 5 — the child and the woman with the lantern as one figure at two times.

Jn 21:15–19 — "Feed my sheep", the handing over of the boat, see chapter 15.

Anchor of truth

What is in the chapter	Status
Six ages of the lantern from hand to hand	ZION telling — Lumi 11 (MYTH; a scenario of handing over, not a prophecy)

"An inheritance can be lost, work can only be done"	ZION telling — Lumi 11 (MYTH)
The right to rewrite what the carpenter wrote without betraying the story	ZION telling — Lumi 11 (MYTH)
Elizabeth and Lumi as one figure at two times	ZION telling — Lumi 5 (MYTH)
The replacement of the cedar and the recutting of the name	STORY — an image of this book

Epilogue · Where the boat anchors today

The pilgrim finished and over the gate the day was breaking. The pinch of salt on his palm had dissolved, the honey in the bowl was gone and Lumi had fallen asleep against his shoulder.

"You said you sail in that boat," said Elizabeth. "You have not answered me yet."

"About what?"

"What will be left of you."

The pilgrim thought. Then he said: "I do not know. But I know where that boat anchors. Not in a harbour and not on the shore. In a heart that opens to others. There is its harbour, not because the world is calm, but because the silence a person seeks is not at the end of the sea. It is within. And sometimes among us, when we sit in one boat."

Elizabeth raised the lantern higher still. Radha poured the last salt into her palm and gave it to the pilgrim to pass on. Before he entered, Elizabeth told him three rights that she tells everyone. "You have the right to verify every word. You have the right to refuse, even the story, if you do not believe it. You have the right to criticise the boat without anyone telling you that you are its enemy. And if any of that is denied you by someone, then it is not this boat, whatever it is called." Then the gate opened quietly.

Let us cross to the other shore, the carpenter once said to his disciples, before the storm rose. Gate, gate, pāragate, says the Heart Sutra: gone, gone, gone to the other shore. Two traditions, two languages, one boat. The keel was laid in Nazareth, the name was

spoken by the lake, and it only remains to sail.

Gate, gate, pāragate, pārasaṃgate, bodhi svāhā.

Anchor of truth

What is in the epilogue	Status
"Let us cross to the other shore"	Scripture — Mk 4:35
Gate, gate, pāragate	Tradition — the mantra of the Heart Sutra (Sanskrit; "gone to the other shore" is a loose translation)
The gate, Radha, Elizabeth, Lumi	STORY — the ZION telling
The link between Mk 4:35 and pāragate	STORY — an image of this book

A note on the labels, and a glossary

Label	What it means
Scripture	A real verse or story from the Bible; quotations are an own translation
Tradition	An interpretation or image from church or Jewish tradition
History	A documented fact outside the Bible
Legend	A tradition told for centuries in various versions
Story	An image or scene that this book imagines
Vision, construction, horizon	The state of a ZION project: an idea, a draft in progress, something that is not yet

Word	Meaning
tektón	in Greek a craftsman, builder; the gospels' word for Jesus's trade
gófer	the wood of which Noah's ark was built; we do not know the species
kofer	pitch; the root of the word "to cover", to reconcile
Kinneret	the Hebrew name of the Sea of Galilee, from kinnor, harp
navicella	Latin for "little ship"; the image of the church as a ship
Tarichea	the Greek name of Magdala, from the word for salted fish